

# 22 The future in the past

There are a number of constructions in English that can be used to describe thoughts about the future that someone had at some point in the past.

See also:

Past continuous 10

Infinitives and participles 51

## 22.1 THE FUTURE IN THE PAST USING "WAS GOING TO"

The future in the past is used to look back on an earlier prediction. Where "going to" is used to talk about the future from the present, "was / were going to" is used to talk about a past view of it.



This traffic is awful! I think  
**I'm going to** be late for work.

I thought **I was going to** be late, but I'm right on time.

### HOW TO FORM

SUBJECT

"WAS / WERE"

"GOING TO"

BASE FORM

REST OF SENTENCE

**I** **was** **going to** **be** **late.**

### FURTHER EXAMPLES

I **was going to** start a new book today, but I didn't have time.



Delia **was going to** buy a new dress, but she couldn't find one.



Mike **was going to** have a party, but nobody could come.



We **were going to** buy a new dog, but we decided to wait.



They **were going to** go home, but they went dancing instead.



Sorry, I interrupted. **Were you going to** say something?

